

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Lexicon 1

How to make a word: An intro to the lexicon for conlangers



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So, I'm making a word for this thing:



In English, we call it a **die** (plural, **dice**). But, what should I call it in my conlang?

This tutorial will go through a number of questions to ask and things to consider as you create your words for your lexicon. But before we dive straight into it, let's define some core vocabulary.

“A **lexicon** is a collection of information about words and similar linguistic expressions in a language.” (Murphy, 2010)

Some related but slightly imprecise words that associate with the lexicon are “dictionary,” “word list,” and “vocabulary.” These terms aren't exactly referring to the same thing as a lexicon.

A dictionary refers specifically to a type of book or document, while a lexicon is primarily stored within the language community - that is, the collective agreement of the language's speakers that A means A and B means B. The dictionary certainly is a physical *representation* of a lexicon, though, and is most likely what you'll be using to store your conlang's lexicon.

A lexicon is not merely a list of words either, but also includes “similar linguistic expressions” such as affixes, idioms, compounds, and the like. Just as phonology has phonemes and morphology has morphemes, lexicons have **lexemes**.

Lexemes are the smallest unit of *meaning* within a sentence.

Lexemes include both free and bound morphemes; it also encompasses phrasal verbs such as “give up,” idioms such as “kick the bucket,” and compounds such as “ice cream.”

In order to be a lexeme, they must be *conventional* and *non-compositional*. That means that lexemes should be agreed upon by the language community and you should not be able to predict what the term means by breaking it into parts.

Non-compositionality is more difficult to understand, so let's take an example: *greenhouse* vs. *green house*. The first is a lexeme - not because there isn't a space in the middle, but because greenhouses are neither green nor (technically) houses. We cannot predict what a ‘greenhouse’ is based on its parts alone. A *green house*, however, is a house that is green, therefore, its meaning is completely predictable from its parts. Another example is “look up” and “look up.” They are orthographically and phonologically identical, but in certain contexts, one is non-compositional while the other is compositional.

“She **looked up** to see the supermoon.” (compositional) “She **looked up** ‘supermoon’ in the dictionary.” (non-compositional)

Finally, all lexemes have **senses**, also known as their ‘denotative meaning’ or ‘dictionary definition.’

A lexeme’s **sense** distinguishes what the lexeme represents from what the lexeme does not represent.

Take for example the following:



dog - a domesticated carnivorous mammal that typically has a long snout, an acute sense of smell, nonretractable claws, and a barking, howling, or whining voice. (Oxford)



NOT A DOG



NOT A DOG



NOT A DOG



NOT A DOG



NOT A DOG

The top-most picture fits the sense of the word “dog.” But the bottom pictures don’t. Why not? Well, the subject on the far left is a domesticated carnivorous mammal with an acute sense of smell and a whiny voice, but it doesn’t have a long snout and its claws are retractable - therefore it isn’t a dog.

The next photo is a domesticated mammal with a long snout and a howling voice. But it’s not carnivorous, has no claws, and isn’t known for its sense of smell.

Next, we have an animal that fits none of the criteria except for being carnivorous. Next, an inanimate object that *might* be described as having a howling voice. Finally, a geologic landmark that has nothing in common with the sense of “dog.”

In other words, the sense of **dog** tells us not only what *is* a dog, but also what *isn’t* a dog.

Meaning Variation

Meaning variation is the situation in which one word has... well, a variety of meanings. Every natural language has a wealth of words that can mean more than one thing. Meaning variation comes in three primary flavors: polysemy, homophony, and vagueness.

Polysemy refers to when a lexeme has multiple related senses.

For example:

- I like to **run** every morning.
- She is **running** for the presidency.
- The refrigerator stopped **running**.
- My nose is **running** because of my allergies.
- Stop **running** your mouth.
- He **ran** a red light and got in an accident.
- The Mississippi River **runs** into the Gulf of Mexico.
- The buses **run** every hour.

In the above sentences, the lexeme “run” is being used to mean multiple different - but somewhat related - things. Polysemy is usually achieved through meaning “shifts,” not entirely unsimilar from how sounds also shift in language, in which one core sense is applied figuratively to other things.

Homophony is when two totally unrelated words happen to be phonologically identical.

A good example is “there,” “their,” and “they’re.” Although they’re spellings and meanings are different, they’re pronounced identically, so there is some element of variation. Some English homonyms are spelled identically as well, like “die (to lose life)” vs. “die (game piece)” or “kind (friendly)” vs. “kind (type).”

Vagueness refers to when a lexeme’s sense is very broad and can refer to a lot of things.

One such word is “sandwich” which refers to a huge variety of different foods with somewhat vague requirements. Another example is “house” which can come in an infinite variety of shapes, constructions, designs, sizes, colors, and functions.

Finally, it’s important to mention **synonyms** as well (even though they don’t technically fall under “meaning variation, but oh well). Those are multiple lexemes that can be used to refer to the same thing (often with different connotations or details). For example “dog” and “canine” are synonyms, although one is more casual than the other. (This is an example of a word’s *connotative definition*, which is the mental association speakers have with a word. E.g., “hi” as an informal connotation while “greetings” has a formal connotation; “interested” has a positive connotation while “nosy” has a negative connotation.)

Back to the Die

Now that the theory is out of the way, let's have some fun and create a word that corresponds to this thing:



In order to do this, I need two things: the lexeme and the sense. I'll be using my main language Wistianian as an example, but you should try doing this with your own language, too!

How to make a lexeme

Lexemes are abstract, and we need sounds to represent them concretely. So, I gotta pull out my phonology and put something together to form a proper Wistianian word. In order to help me come up with the word, I'll use a variety of tactics:

1. Just make something up on the fly with something that sounds good to me.
2. Try putting the lexeme in a sentence represented with a ___, saying the sentence out loud, and filling in the blank with whatever comes to head first.
3. Loan a word from a natural language or a friend's conlang.
4. Look through my dictionary and find any holes or patterns that I don't use often and use it in the word.
5. Use a word generator like [Awkwords](#).

For this word, I'm gonna use the fourth tactic. Going through my dictionary, there's a telling lack of words without <uhi> [ufi], which is one of my favorite patterns in Wistianian words. Next, I'll find a consonant sound that does not have a lot of words that start with it followed by <u>. The first consonant I could find is, luckily, . So my word is going to at least start with <buhi>. I can either end it with a consonant or leave it as is. I think I'm going to settle for <buhi> since I can easily verbalize it via zero derivation as "to roll a die" and get some cool conjugation patterns like <buhaya>.

So the lexeme is <buhi> [mbufi] in both its nominal and verbal forms.

How to make a sense

The sense is the fun part. Let's think about the English sense for a second. The prototypical die is used to play many different games, from Monopoly to Farkle to deciding whether or not Qui-Gon Jinn can free Anakin. It's a six-sided plastic cube with different amounts of dots on each side. We roll them, and whatever side faces up once it stops decides what the player is allowed or required to do in their game.

Now, let's think creatively for a second. What else could a die look like? What else could it be used for? How else could it be interpreted?

We already know that dice can come in four-sided varieties, as well as ten-sided and twenty-sided and so forth. The dots can also be replaced with numerals, letters, colors, or images. We basically only use them for games, but could we also use them to settle disputes or make decisions (like we often do with coin tosses)? What about how we interpret them? Basically everyone agrees that the side facing up is the side that we follow, but why not the side that faces down or the side that faces the roller?

It's also helpful to consider the fact that Wistania doesn't have plastic. It's most likely that they would make their dice out of stone, which is a lot more difficult to mold.

So, with all those questions in mind, let's answer them.

Wistanians primarily use dice for playing games - nothing particularly novel there - and they interpret the winning side to be the one that is facing up. However, the sides of the dice are distinguished by color - not number. The reason for this is that color is very important to Wistanian culture. Color has a lot more meaning to them than number does.

Dice are made of soft stone and are predominately six-sided because cubes are easier shapes to carve. Now that I've thought this through, I'm ready to write my entry:

bui [mbuɸi] *count n.* // a six-sided die made of stone with different colors on each side, used to play games.

I decided not to mention that the side facing up is the side that wins because I feel like that doesn't need to be specified. I can then make an entry for the verbalized version:

bui [mbuɸi] *v.* // to roll a die; to take a risk.

Notice that I threw in a little bit of polysemy in there to expand upon the meaning some more.

Conclusions and FAQ

There is an infinite amount of possibilities when creating your lexicon. I usually take this as an opportunity to “worldbuild as I wordbuild” and develop both the language and the people that speak it. There was one point in my conlanging journey where I wanted to create 2,500 words in a single year. It’s doable, but none of the words I made really *meant* anything. They were just Wistanian sounds correlated with English translations. By going slow and taking time to detail and expand, I’ve found my lexicon - and therefore my conlang and its speakers - to be much more interesting.

To end off, I want to quickly address some quick FAQs:

How many words do I need?

As many as you need. Trying to translate a sentence but don’t have a word for “to throw”? Then, the answer is that you need one more word. Natural languages have massive lexicons that are edited, expanded, and shifted all the time. If your goal is to have a small vocabulary, the conlang with the least amount of words would likely be Toki Pona with 120, so shoot for somewhere around that number.

How do you know which words to make?

There are a lot of ways to do this. My preferred method is translating sentences and stories to your conlang because - not only does it expand your lexicon - it puts your lexicon into context, and also helps you practice your grammar. I would personally recommend staying away from word lists like Swadesh because they give this false sense of having “core vocabulary” and often facilitate copying English definitions onto your conlang’s words.

How do I store my lexicon?

I store mine in a Word Document. If I’m in a hurry, I have a separate txt file that I’ll throw words and simple translations into so that I can go back and expand on them later. I’ve used Google Sheets before, but I always run out of room in the column for definitions. There are also a number of websites and programs that you can store your lexicon in such as [Lexiconga](#), [Conlang Workshop](#), and [Polyglot](#). We’ll be talking more in depth about documenting conlangs in the next couple weeks.

When should I start on my lexicon?

As soon as you feel comfortable. Most guides will recommend settling on your phonology before creating words, and that’s what I would recommend, too.

My dictionary is outdated. What do I do?

Ah yes. Wistanian has five different dictionaries. Yep. I started over *five times*. Each time I learned something new, changed something different, or wanted something fresh. In this situation, you can either go through your current dictionary and make edits where appropriate or start all over again with a blank dictionary. There’s nothing wrong with either of those options. Time is an illusion.

How should I design my dictionary?

I recommend looking at other dictionaries to see how the professionals do it. Typically, the headword will be in bold, followed by pronunciation, part of speech, and numbered definitions. You can take what you like and change what you don't, but I'd say the only hard rule is to make sure your headwords are easy to find in a sea of text. If you store your dictionary in a spreadsheet, then you have a lot more freedom as the headword would naturally be a lot simpler to find.

Happy Conlanging!